

Derek Staley

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Summary

Delivery and program leader with 13 years across tech, games, and entertainment. I've launched new products and verticals, built Agile delivery from scratch, and kept cross-functional teams aligned through complex execution. Now I'm moving into product management. To get there, I've built two products end to end and made every product decision on them. Case studies available at dcstaley.github.io. Certified Scrum Master.

Independent Product Development

Unified Tasks & Habits App | Personal Project, 2026 – Present · productivity-app-five-eta.vercel.app (desktop only)

A local-first daily planner that unifies tasks, habits, and calendar events on one view. All requirements, specs, and roadmap owned by me. Built with Claude Code.

- Designed the app around a single item model, where a task, a calendar event, and a habit are one underlying item with time, repeat, and tracking as optional layers. It closes the gap left by tools that keep the three apart
- Owned the PRD, user stories with acceptance criteria, a competitive analysis, and the information and technical architecture, versioned and kept current as the build proceeded
- Shipped v1 in three planned phases, covering flexible scheduling, habit tracking, tags, notes, completion history, Google Calendar sync, and week/month views
- v2 in active development, adding analytics, reminders, and richer habit goals, prioritized from features intentionally deferred out of v1

Roster Optimizer for Out of the Park Baseball | Personal Project, 2025 – Present

An analytics web app for a baseball simulation video game. All requirements, scoring logic, and feature specs owned by me. Built with Claude Code.

- Diagnosed v1's failure with a file-by-file audit (scores computed two different ways), then rebuilt around a single scoring core consumed identically by the grid, optimizer, and validation, removing the drift behind most of v1's bugs
- Made the prediction model a swappable component and let a bake-off on real season outcomes choose it, retiring "match the old app's scores" as the goal once the data-trained model won
- Specified a HiGHS linear-programming optimizer for optimal 26-player rosters under budget, eligibility, tier, two-way, and lineup constraints; live in competitive play

Selected Professional Work

Producer, Demiurge Studios

2023 – 2025

- Led feature prioritization and roadmap planning for Riot Games across Teamfight Tactics and 2XKO, balancing product vision, design intent, and technical feasibility
- Turned product direction from Riot's product and design leads into clear, well-scoped plans with defined acceptance criteria
- Kept Riot's game teams and Demiurge's engineering and art aligned on requirements, priorities, and deliverables across both engagements

Program Manager, MGM Resorts International

2021 – 2023

- Built production and delivery processes for a newly formed product and development team, including agile workflow, backlog management, sprint cadence, and tooling
- Partnered with finance and business stakeholders on budget planning, staffing, and resource decisions across multiple concurrent roadmaps
- Collaborated with the Lead Product Manager on roadmap planning to establish realistic timelines and prioritization

Senior Project Manager, The Zebra

2019 – 2021

- Joined as an early PM hire and established company-wide best practices, policies, and tooling from the ground up
- Led the launch of the home insurance vertical, the first major extension of the core business, from initial scoping through go-to-market execution
- Established executive-level reporting dashboards providing visibility into delivery health, blockers, and progress as the organization scaled
- Mentored engineering leads and managers on Agile processes, estimation, and backlog prioritization

Agile Project Manager, Confluence Inc

2017 – 2019

- Led the dev support team, designing processes for prioritizing client requests alongside planned development work
- Established company-wide processes to predict and communicate the timing of bug fixes, patches, and new features, improving client satisfaction and stakeholder transparency
- Led the transition of a 20-year-old engineering team onto modern agile processes, including backlog management, sprint planning, and retrospectives

Project Manager, Ellation (Crunchyroll)

2016 – 2017

- Led the launch of VRV, a new video streaming platform, simultaneously shipping on iOS, Android, Xbox One, and PS4 and hitting all target launch dates through tight scope and resourcing decisions
- Created dashboards surfacing critical path items and blockers for both engineering teams and executive leadership
- Partnered with technical leadership to implement live deployment processes across all backend services

Project Manager, Big Fish Games

2015 – 2016

- Ran planning and execution for live updates on a top-10 grossing iOS and Android game, coordinating across development, product, QA, and marketing

Project Manager, Branding Brand

2013 – 2014

- Managed delivery for remote international client teams and launched the company's first international travel site

Associate Product Manager, Kixeye

2011 – 2013

- Partnered with game design and UX to build, test, and ship new features, owning quality from development through launch

Skills

Product: Product Management, Product Roadmapping, Feature Prioritization, Product Discovery, PRDs, User Stories & Acceptance Criteria, Competitive Analysis

Delivery: Backlog Management, Agile, Scrum, Kanban, Jira, Confluence, Program Management, Project Management

Leadership & Collaboration: Cross-functional Leadership, Stakeholder Management, Executive Communication, Team Mentorship

AI & Data: AI-Directed Development, Generative AI, Prompt Engineering, Claude Code, Data Analysis

Certifications: Certified Scrum Master (CSM)

Education

B.S., Information Science and Technology — Penn State University